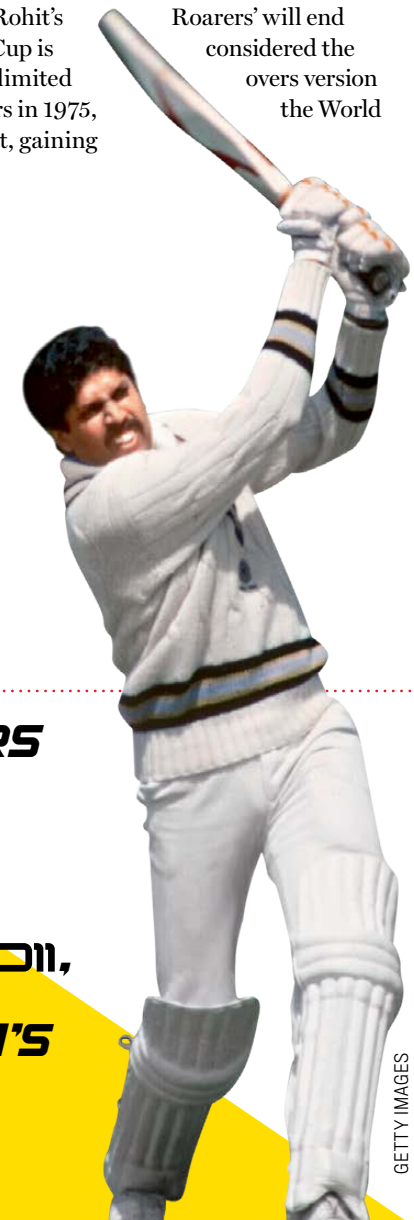
Team India captain Rohit Sharma was just beginning to field questions from the press after India's thumping win in the Asia Cup final when he was interrupted by the deafening sound of crackers being burst outside. He paused, allowed the noise to die down and then, almost instinctively, remarked, "World Cup *jeetne ke baad phodo, yaar* (Burst the crackers after we win the World Cup, guys)!" While Rohit's comment was in jest, it does encapsulate the mood of a cricket-mad country that has been experiencing an extended title drought at the world level since 2011 when M.S. Dhoni led the Indian team to victory.

There could be no better time and place to end that pain than the 2023 edition of the ODI (one-day international) World Cup. If there was a 28-year gap between the time Dhoni's Daredevils lifted the cup and when Kapil's Devils won it for the first time in 1983, the hope is that 'Rohit's Roarers' will end the impasse in this edition. The ODI World Cup is considered the G20 of cricket, the epitome of the white ball limited overs version of the game. Since the inception of one-dayers in 1975, the World Cup has emerged as cricket's showpiece event, gaining worldwide acceptance and also the biggest prize money in the sport—the 2023 edition has a total purse of $10 million or Rs 83.3 crore. The previous edition saw a global cumulative live audience of 1.6 billion viewers: expect a jump by at least 40 per cent this time as the circus moves across 10 venues, covering a total of 48 games spread across 46 days.

INDIA'S STRENGTHS

So can the Indian team pull it off? Truth be told, since the 2011 triumph, they have been found wanting on the biggest stage, especially at crucial junctures (see box *Dry as Dust*). The word was out—India can be beaten, and beaten in various ways. The Men in Blue arrived in Sri Lanka for the Asia Cup last month with questions aplenty: the openers had been misfiring; Virat Kohli had endured an extended dry patch in ODIs; K.L. Rahul and Shreyas Iyer's match fitness were in doubt; all-rounder Hardik Pandya hadn't been in action as a bowler for long; bowlers Shardul Thakur and Axar Patel seemed to be in the team not on the dint of their performances, but out of the sheer need to have all-rounders to balance the playing XI; and ace speedster Jasprit Bumrah was returning from a long-term injury with no evidence to show that he had regained the form or the strength to bowl the 10-over quota. Four weeks on, all doubts have been laid to rest, the Indian XI has answered emphatically, dominating the continental

INDIA HAD TO WAIT 28 YEARS AFTER KAPIL'S DEVILS FIRST LIFTED THE WORLD CUP IN '83. AFTER 2011, WILL THIS BE ROHIT SHARMA'S SWANSONG?



GETTY IMAGES